Multi-Landy (Woolsey)

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Multi-Landy (Woolsey) is a convention used after the opponents open 1NT. It gets its name from the use of the Landy 2♣ overcall and Multi 2♦ convention. The "Woolsey" aspect comes from the multiple possible meanings of a double, as invented by Kit Woolsey.

It should be noted that Woolsey uses this approach against a strong 1NT only. His weak 1NT defense includes natural penalty doubles, among other differences.

The 2-level overcalls are the same as Cappelletti, except that the meanings of the 2♣ and 2♦ bids are reversed.

Playing Cappelletti, overcaller might bid 2♦ with 4 hearts and 5 spades. Then with 3-3 majors, responder signs off in 2♥ and misses the spade fit. Playing Multi-Landy, responder has an extra bid — 2♦ — to ask for opener's major suit preference.

Conventional Overcalls of 1NT

In ACBL events, the Multi-Landy double and overcalls are all alertable.

Overcall	Meaning
Double	Varies by partnership agreement. Here is a comprehensive method -- known as the Woolsey Double -- asoutlined by David Oakley in "Multi-Landy: The Killer Defense Versus One Notrump".[1] • A 4-card major with a 5+ card minor. • A 6+ card minor. • A "strong" major, i.e. 5+ suit. • A strong balanced hand (19+ HCP vs. strong no-trumps, and 15+ HCP vs.weak no-trumps). Alternatively in "The Mysterious Multi", Mark Horton and Jan van Cleef propose double as the major-minor hand type vs. strong no-trumps, and simply penalty vs. weak no-trumps.[2]
2♣	At least 5-4 or 4-5 in hearts and spades; rarely 4-4. (This is the Landy aspect of the convention.)
2♦	6 hearts or spades (rarely 5) without a side suit. (This is the Multi aspect.)
2♥	5 hearts and a 4+ card minor. (This is the Cappelletti aspect.)
2♠	5 spades and a 4+ card minor. (This is also the Cappelletti aspect.)
2NT	At least 5-5 in clubs and diamonds.

Responses to the Double

Response	Meaning
2♣	Tolerance for both minors (at least 3-3). Asks partner to pass or correct. Partner will:

- Pass with a one-suiter in clubs, OR with clubs + a 4-card major
- Bid 2♦ with a one-suiter in diamonds, OR with diamonds + a 4-card major
- Bid 2♥ or 2♠ with a strong single suiter
- Bid 2NT with a strong balanced hand

2♦ Tolerance for both majors (at least 3-3). Asks partner to bid his major suit. Partner will:

- Pass with a one-suiter in diamonds
- Bid 2♥ or 2♠ to show 4 cards in that suit
- Bid 2NT with a strong balanced hand
- Correct to 3♣ with a one-suiter in clubs

2♥ Natural, 6+ hearts, nonforcing.

2♠ Natural, 6+ spades, nonforcing.

2NT Varies by partnership agreement. According to Horton and van Cleef, this is artificial and forcing with at least 4-4 in the majors. Asks the overcaller to clarify his hand.[3] Overcaller's responses are:

- 3♣ Natural, minimum strength.
- 3♦ Natural, minimum strength.
- 3♥ Natural, maximum strength.
- 3♠ Natural, maximum strength.

3♣ Natural, 6+ good clubs, nonforcing.

3♦ Natural, 6+ good diamonds, nonforcing.

Responses to the 2♣ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	Natural, 6+ good clubs, nonforcing.
2♦	Equal length in the majors. Asks partner to pick one. With 5-4 in the majors, for example, partner will correct to the 5-card major.
2♥	Natural sign-off, showing a preference for hearts even if partner is 5-4 in spades and hearts.
2♠	Natural sign-off, showing a preference for spades even if partner is 4-5 in spades and hearts.
2NT	Varies by partnership agreement. Horton and van Cleeff propose that 2NT is strong, artificial, and forcing. Overcaller can rebid as follows.[4]

- 3♣ Better hearts, not minimum.
- 3♦ Better spades, not minimum.
- 3♥ Longer hearts (or 4-4), minimum.
- 3♠ Longer spades, minimum.
- 3NT 5-5 or better, maximum.

Alternatively, British expert Neil Rosen simply proposes that 2NT is simply natural and balanced with 12-14 points, nonforcing.[5]

Responses to the 2♦ Overcall

Response	Meaning
2♥	Natural signoff if overcaller has hearts. However, this bid may also be made with game-invitational values in spades. If overcaller corrects to 2♠, then partner is allowed to raise to 3♠.
2♠	Natural signoff if overcaller has spades. However, this may also show game-invitational values in hearts. If overcaller corrects to 3♥, then partner is allowed to raise to 4♥.
2NT	Artificial, forcing. Asks the overcaller to clarify his hand. Overcaller's responses are:

3♣ shows 5+ hearts, maximum strength.
3♦ shows 5+ spades, maximum strength.
3♥ shows 5+ hearts, minimum strength.
3♠ shows 5+ spades, minimum strength.

(Some pairs may switch the minimum and maximum meanings, but "fast arrival" seems a bit more appropriate with the weak hands.)

Responses to the 2♥ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	To play.
2♠	Natural, 6+ good spades, no heart support, nonforcing.
2NT	Artificial, no heart support, asks partner to bid his minor.
3♣	Natural, 6+ good clubs, no heart support, nonforcing.
3♦	Natural, 6+ good diamonds, no heart support, nonforcing.
3♥	Preemptive, 3+ hearts. Nonforcing.
3♠	Natural, preemptive, 6+ good spades, no heart support. Nonforcing.
3NT	To play.
4♥	To play.
4♠	To play.

Responses to the 2♠ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	To play.
2NT	Artificial, no spade support, asks partner to bid his minor.
3♣	Natural, 6+ good clubs, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♦	Natural, 6+ good diamonds, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♥	Natural, 6+ good hearts, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♠	Preemptive, 3+ spades. Nonforcing.
3NT	To play.
4♥	To play.
4♠	To play.

Responses to the 2NT Overcall

Response	Meaning
3♣	To play.
3♦	To play. Tends to deny club support.
3♥	Natural, 6+ good hearts, no support for either minor, nonforcing.
3♠	Natural, 6+ good spades, no support for either minor, nonforcing.
3NT	To play.
4♣	3+ clubs, invitational to 5♣.

4♦	3+ diamonds, invitational to 5♦.
4♥	To play.
4♠	To play.

In Competition

What if the opponents compete over the Woolsey action? For instance:

West	North	East	South
1NT	Dbl*	2-any	?

West	North	East	South
1NT	2-any*	Dbl	?

West	North	East	South
1NT	2-any*	2-any	?

Oakley suggests the following scheme in these auctions:[6]

Response	**Meaning**
Raise of partner's suit	Natural.
New suit	Natural.
Double / Redouble	Showing interest in one of partner's suits, with emphasis on a major.
2NT	Showing both minors (opposite a Woolsey double), or asking for overcaller's strength.

Additionally, if the opponents specifically redouble a Woolsey double:

West	North	East	South
1NT	Dbl	Redbl	?

...Horton and van Cleeff state:[7]

> Woolsey recommends agreeing that pass here is to play, and otherwise ignoring the redouble (i.e. bids mean the same as if East had passed). There are other things one can do of course, but it is not a bad philosophy to ignore enemy doubles and redoubles in conventional situations and have bids mean what they would have meant had the enemy passed — much easier on the memory.

In comparison, Oakley recommends:[8]

Response	**Meaning**
Pass	Support for partner's minor.
2♣	Artificial relay to partner's major OR 2♦.
2♦	Natural.

Examples

The following hands come from Kit Woolsey and Bart Bramley in the 2019 Open USBC.[9]

Vul: E-W	Ginossar	
Dlr: East	♠A85	
	♥J73	
Woolsey	♦J87	Bramley
♠63	♣T652	♠KQT42
♥KQ95		♥864
♦A93	Willenken	♦KT65
♣K873	♠J97	♣4
	♥AT2	
	♦Q42	
	♣AQJ9	

Willenken	Woolsey	Ginossar	Bramley
			Pass
1NT[1]	Pass	Pass	2♠
All Pass			

1. Strong 1NT (14-16)
2. Spades and a minor

Bramley balanced with 8 HCP at unfavorable vulnerability, but emerged with an overtrick.

Vul: E-W	Ginossar	
Dlr: East	♠AKJ3	
	♥A32	
Woolsey	♦A42	Bramley
♠QT65	♣542	♠2
♥KT94		♥QJ87
♦KT7	Willenken	♦J953
♣J8	♠9874	♣KT76
	♥65	
	♦Q86	
	♣AQ93	

Willenken	Woolsey	Ginossar	Bramley
Pass	Pass	1NT[1]	Pass
Pass	2♣[2]	Pass	2♥[3]
Dbl	Pass	2NT	All Pass

1. Strong 1NT (14-16)
2. Showing majors with only 4-4 shape in the balancing seat
3. Taking a preference

Woolsey-Bramley pushed the opponents into 2NT, just making.

Vul: E-W	Ginossar

Dlr: East	♠6 ♥Q62	
Woolsey	♦9732	Bramley
♠AQJ972	♣65432	♠T84
♥J9		♥KT843
♦KQJ	Willenken	♦654
♣KT	♠K53	♣Q8
	♥A75	
	♦AT8	
	♣AJ97	

Willenken	Woolsey	Ginossar	Bramley
		Pass	Pass
1NT[1]	2♦[2]	Pass	2♠[3]
All Pass			

1. Strong 1NT (14-16)
2. A major suiter
3. Taking a preference; happy if partner corrects to hearts

South led a trump. Bramley managed to successfully finesse both majors, finishing with two overtricks.

Origins

Multi-Landy has a multi-generational history. It's based on the original Landy convention from the 1950s whereby a simple 2♣ overcall of 1NT showed both majors. Since then it's inherited aspects of the Cappelletti convention, Muiderberg Two Bids, Multi 2♦ and the Woolsey Double.

References

- [1], [6], [8] Oakley, David. Multi-Landy 2nd Edition. Toronto, Master Point Press, 2018.
- [2], [3], [4], [7] Horton, Mark and Jan van Cleeff. The Mysterious Multi. Toronto, Master Point Press, 2010.
- [5] Rosen, Neil. (2012, October.) Multi-Landy. English Bridge, Issue 243.
- [9] 2019 Open USBC Results.

See also

- Cappelletti (Hamilton)
  A defense to 1NT in which double is for penalty, and 2-level overcalls are conventional.
- Landy
  A (very old) defense to 1NT in which a 2♣ overcall shows both majors.
- Meckwell Defense to 1NT
  A defensive bidding structure for use against both weak and strong 1NT opening bids.
- Multi 2♦
  An artificial 2♦ opening bid showing either a major suit preempt or a strong 4441 hand.